

THE SELLER'S GUIDE

An Insider's Guide to Selling Your Home in *San Francisco*

A teach-first walk-through of how your home actually gets sold here — the pricing, the paperwork, the timeline, and the number that lands in your pocket.

First, and *foremost.*

You're about to sell what's probably your largest asset, in one of the most competitive markets in the country. How you go about it matters — so thank you for letting me walk you through it.

I made this guide because I teach first. Before we ever talk price or timing, I want you to actually understand the moves in front of you — a seller who gets the strategy makes calmer, better decisions, and calm decisions are what protect your equity.

So this isn't a pitch. It's the plain-English version of everything I wish every seller knew before they listed: what your home is really worth, the SF paperwork nobody warns you about, what's worth fixing and what isn't, and what selling actually costs when the dust settles.

Read it at your own pace. There's no clock running, and there's no pressure from me. When you're ready to talk about your specific home, I'll be right here.

Claudia



MY ONE PROMISE

I'll never hand you a price without seeing your home in person and running the comps. No automated Zestimate, no number over text to win your business. Anyone who blurts a figure before they've seen your kitchen is selling you, not helping you.

WHO I AM, BRIEFLY

An SF REALTOR® at Vantage, running the *Claudia Insider* brand on one idea: real estate should be taught, not sold. I bring the branding, marketing, and tech side of a modern home launch — backed by a hyper-local team with deep SF experience. A little more on both of us, next page.

Fun fact — I'm a 3× US national team member and multiple-time national karate champion. Turns out staying calm under pressure is a very transferable skill!

A hyper-local team, and a *human* to run it.

You're not hiring one person — you're getting a boutique San Francisco firm behind you, and an agent who genuinely loves the presentation side. Here's the pairing that goes to work on your sale.



THE TEAM — YOUR SUPPORT

Vantage agents are **hyper-local**. We read the city's micromarkets and its seasonality block by block — not "San Francisco" as one market, but your corner of it, this time of year. The team carries real tenure and standing in the SF real estate community, which is exactly the muscle you want behind your pricing and your negotiation.

And Vantage runs on **Side** — the platform powering a top-tier national network — so a boutique, personal experience comes with serious tools, marketing, and legal support underneath it.

WHAT I BRING — YOUR LEAD

- **Branding & marketing** — presenting your home is what I do all day. Media, a property website, and social reach that actually moves.
- **Tech-savvy launch** — a modern, polished rollout, not a tired MLS post.
- **A human to work with** — I keep it collaborative, clear, and low-stress, whether I'm selling your home or representing you as your agent on the next one.

THE VANTAGE TEAM • REALTRENDS VERIFIED, 2025

#1	#3	\$600M+	\$230M+	Top 0.1%
SF LARGE TEAM, AVG. SALE PRICE	SF LARGE TEAM, BY SALES VOLUME	SOLD SINCE FOUNDING, 2023	VOLUME YEAR-TO-DATE	IN CA & U.S., REALTRENDS

Vantage Realty team performance — RealTrends-verified (2025), and a Leading 100 Bay Area team. I'll share current neighborhood numbers for your specific sale.

Local team muscle, plus a marketing-and-tech-forward agent who keeps it human. That's the combination working for you.

YOUR CORNER

What's *inside*.

Twelve short chapters, in the order they'll actually happen. Skip around if you like — but if you read only three, make them pricing, the SF paperwork, and what it all costs. Those are where sales are quietly won or lost.

01 **Is it the right time — for you?**
Reading the SF market for your situation, not the headlines.

02 **What your home is really worth**
Comps, why list price is marketing, and the SF underpricing game.

03 **Getting your home ready**
What's worth doing, what to skip, and the ROI reality.

04 **The paperwork most sellers don't expect**
The disclosure package, inspections, and SF-only reports.

05 **Condos, TICs & multi-unit**
The extra steps when it's not a single-family home.

06 **The timeline & what to expect**
Decision to close, in realistic weeks.

07 **What good marketing looks like**
What to look for — not a highlight reel.

08 **Offers & negotiation**
Why the highest offer isn't always the best one.

09 **What selling actually costs**
Commissions, SF transfer tax, and your net sheet.

10 **Selling and buying at once**
The whiplash, and how people pull it off.

11 **Closing & the little things**
Escrow, PG&E, Recology, keys, done.

12 **A note to end on**
No hard sell. Just an open door.

The only market that matters is *yours.*

People ask me if it's a good time to sell like there's one answer for the whole city. There isn't. The right time is the one that fits **your** life — the move, the school year, the next chapter — and the honest question is whether the market will support that plan right now.

That's a conversation, not a Zestimate. I'll show you what's actually happening in your neighborhood and price point, tell you plainly whether the timing helps or hurts you, and if the answer is "wait a beat," I'll say so. Rushing a sale to hit an arbitrary date is how homes end up sitting.

And here's the part most sellers don't realize about San Francisco: **comps move by the day and the week, not month to month.** A single strong sale two blocks over can reset what your home is worth in a weekend. So pricing isn't a number we lock in today and dust off in three months — it's a moving target we read fresh, close to launch.

If you decide to hold off, that's not a setback. We just revisit the pricing conversation when you're ready, with current numbers. Keeping it accurate *is* the strategy.



THE INSIDER BIT

Because comps move so fast here, I don't do the "list it high and see" thing. We set price close to launch, off the freshest sales — that's chapter 02. It's the single biggest reason SF pricing feels different from everywhere else.

WHAT I'LL BRING YOU

A real read on your block and price band: what's selling, what's sitting, and what a buyer will actually pay this month — walked through in person, not emailed as a guess.

"Not sure yet" is a completely fine answer. My job in that season is to keep you informed until the timing is genuinely right — no pressure to move before it is.

ON TIMING

List price is marketing. *Value* is what a buyer pays.

These are two different numbers, and confusing them is the most expensive mistake a seller can make. Value is set by recent comparable sales — what real buyers actually paid for homes like yours. List price is a lever we pull to attract them.

The SF move: price to start a conversation

In much of San Francisco — especially single-family homes in strong pockets — the winning strategy is to price a touch **below** what we expect it to fetch, then set an offer date and let buyers compete. As one agent I respect puts it: what do buyers love most? Other buyers.

It works because our buyers have every comp at their fingertips. Price it right and a crowd shows up on day one, feels the competition, and bids the number *up*. It's not a gimmick — in recent years the large majority of SF single-family homes have sold over asking. But it only works when the price invites a crowd.

Why overpricing quietly costs you

Overpricing feels safe — “we can always come down.” But an overpriced home sits, and in SF a stale listing is loud. Buyers watch days-on-market and price cuts, and a reduction reads as “*what’s wrong with it?*” The irony: homes priced to compete often sell for more than homes priced high, because momentum in the first two weeks is everything.

WHERE UNDERPRICING DOES NOT APPLY

It's not universal, and I'll never force it on the wrong home. Above roughly \$5M the strategy fades, and at the very top it flips — luxury buyers want to feel they got a deal, so those homes are priced high and negotiated. Condos and downtown listings usually do best with straight, transparent pricing too. Your home's type and price band decide the play.

THE CMA — AKA MY HONEST READ

I hand you a comparative market analysis in person: here's what it'll likely sell for and *why*, comp by comp. I want you to understand the number, not just accept it. Ask me anything about it — that's the point.

WHY WE SET PRICE CLOSE TO LAUNCH

Remember chapter 01: comps move weekly here. So we finalize your number near go-live off the freshest sales, not weeks early off stale ones. It keeps you accurate — and accurate is what sells.

Spend where it *pays back*. Skip where it doesn't.

Prep is a menu, not a mandate. The goal isn't to renovate — it's to help buyers fall for the home in photos and in person. The honest truth from the data: presentation and light cosmetics reliably return; big remodels right before selling generally don't.

Usually worth it

● RELIABLE RETURN

- Staging — the most consistent lift in SF
- Fresh paint, inside and out
- Deep clean & declutter
- Refinishing existing hardwood floors
- Lighting & fixture refresh
- Curb appeal / tidy landscaping
- Small repairs — the punch list
- Pro photography & floor plans

It depends

● SITUATIONAL

- New flooring (vs. refinishing what's there)
- A minor kitchen refresh — hardware, paint
- Countertops / lighting on higher-end homes
- Pre-sale inspections & a clean disclosure package (see ch. 04)

Usually skip

○ RARELY RECOUPED BEFORE A SALE

- Full kitchen or bath remodels
- Additions & major structural work
- HVAC swaps as a "value" play
- Bold, personal finish choices

STAGING, HONESTLY

In SF, staging is close to expected on most non-tenant-occupied homes. Roughly half of sellers' agents say it shortens time on market, and buyers' agents overwhelmingly say it helps buyers picture living there.

Typical SF ranges: ~\$4k for a 1-bed, ~\$12–15k for a 3-bed, and up toward \$40k on luxury homes — vacant staging (rental furniture) at the top of the range.

Trust the staging even when it isn't how you'd live. It's built for the camera and the buyer, not for Tuesday nights.

HOW I KEEP PREP OFF YOUR PLATE

Life doesn't stop because you're selling. With your okay, I line up and schedule the vendors — paint, floors, cleaning, staging, lighting, landscaping, floor plans — from Vantage's tried list, often at preferred pricing. We talk budget honestly up front and spend only where it earns its keep.

The disclosure package — aka your home's *baggage*.

Every SF home comes to market with a fat stack of disclosures and reports. It looks intimidating, but here's the reframe: getting *ahead* of it is one of the biggest things that protects your sale. A buyer who's had every question answered up front writes a cleaner, more confident offer. This is the part I geek out on — I sit in a disclosure seminar most weeks.

WHAT GOES IN THE PACKAGE

- **Your seller disclosures** — the statewide TDS plus SF's own supplemental form, where you tell buyers what you know. Over-share here; it protects you.
- **Natural Hazard report (NHD)** — flood, fire, seismic and fault zones. Ordered from a third party (~\$75–150).
- **Lead-based paint disclosure** — required for any home built before 1978.
- **Agent visual inspection (AVID)** — what your agent observed, room by room.
- **Preliminary title report** — who's on title and anything recorded against the home. (In SF, the buyer customarily covers title & escrow — nice for you.)

THE SF-SPECIFIC REPORTS

- **The 3R Report** — the city's Report of Residential Building Record: permit history and legal use. About \$286 from SF DBI; allow 7–10 business days, so we order early.
- **Pre-sale pest (WDO) inspection** — Section 1 is active issues/damage; Section 2 is conditions that could lead to them.
- **General / property inspection** — the whole-home checkup. In SF it's customary for the seller to pre-inspect so buyers can offer without contingencies.
- **Energy & water compliance** — SF requires energy (RECO) and water-conservation upgrades at sale, with a certificate recorded before title transfers. Usually modest; I manage it.
- **Sometimes:** a sewer lateral scope, roof, or foundation report, depending on the home.

WHY "GET AHEAD OF IT" IS THE WHOLE GAME

Disclosed problems are far cheaper than surprised buyers. When the package is complete and honest before we list, buyers can review, sign, and write clean offers — and nothing detonates the deal in week three. I attend the pest and general inspections in person, build the package for full transparency, and translate every scary-sounding line into plain English for you. That's the differentiator I bring.

Figures and requirements move — the 3R fee and compliance rules get updated periodically, and I confirm the current numbers for your specific home and sale.

Condos, TICs & multi-unit: the *extra* steps.

Single-family homes are only about a quarter of SF's housing — which is exactly why they command a premium. If yours is a condo, a TIC, or a building with tenants, a few more moving parts get added to the package. None are scary once you know they're coming.

IF IT'S A CONDO

The HOA docs

By law we request and deliver the HOA package: CC&Rs, budgets, reserve study, insurance, and the last 12 months of meeting minutes. The HOA has 10 days to produce them and charges a fee (often ~\$400–600). Buyers — and their lenders — read the building's financial health as closely as your unit.

IF IT'S A TIC

One parcel, shared

A tenancy-in-common shares one deed, so we surface the TIC agreement, any fractional-loan terms, and how the group shares costs. Financing is more specialized, which shapes your buyer pool — so we market it accordingly and price with that in mind.

IF THERE ARE TENANTS

Rent control & rights

SF layers on tenant protections. Before selling rental units you must give tenants a written notice, and we disclose rents, tenancy dates, and status to buyers. Estoppel forms confirm the details — though tenants aren't required to sign them.

THE VALUE LEVER NOBODY EXPLAINS

A vacant, conversion-eligible two-unit building sits at the top of the market; a comparable building with a long-term tenant can be worth dramatically less, because you can't price an occupied building off vacant comps. If your building has tenants, I map the real options — and their value impact — before we set a number.

DECKS, BALCONIES & BIG BUILDINGS

Three-plus-unit buildings have their own inspection laws for decks and balconies (the "EEE" checks), and an un-repaired finding can even hold up a buyer's loan. In larger buildings I read the reserves and minutes for special-assessment risk early, so it's handled — not discovered.

Decision to closed, in *real* weeks.

Decide & prep

≈ 3–12 WEEKS

The longest stretch, and where a sale is won. Repairs, staging, photography, and the disclosure package all come together. Cosmetic-only homes can be ready in 2–4 weeks; anything needing permits runs months.

Coming soon

≈ 1 WEEK

A soft launch — aka building demand before we hit the open market. Sign goes up, buyers get teased, the property website goes live.

Live on the market

≈ 1–2 WEEKS

Public. Broker tour, the big open-house push, daily activity. This is the loud phase — and where my daily hustle shows up.

Offer date

A SINGLE DAY

Offers come in together and we review as a group. Strong homes often take a pre-emptive offer before the date.

In escrow

≈ 3–6 WEEKS

Deposit, appraisal, and remaining conditions. When buyers waive contingencies, this can move fast — around 21 days.

Closed

KEYS HANDED OVER

It records, funds land, and it's done.



OPEN-HOUSE DAY IS THE BIG ONE

I don't do the 2–4pm Sunday cameo. I host a full, all-day open house — sign-in, market data out, refreshments, a real presence — because a room full of buyers is what turns interest into offers. I tour SF every week, so I know how to read the traffic and tell you honestly what it means.

YOU'LL HEAR FROM ME — A LOT

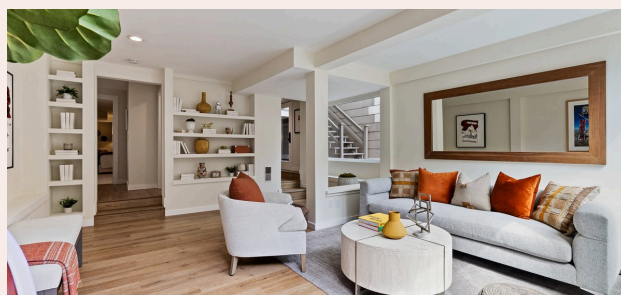
This stretch is anxious-making, so I check in regularly, especially once you're live and in escrow. Don't panic-read the quiet of week one; I'll tell you what the feedback actually means.

Ranges assume a healthy market; a cosmetic-ready home can go from decision to closed in roughly 6–9 weeks, while a home needing permitted work runs longer. I'll map your real calendar to your home.

What to *look for* — not a highlight reel.

You'll see a lot of agents promise "marketing." Here's how to tell strong from weak, whoever you hire. The homes that sell faster and for more are the ones with media-rich, multi-channel launches — and the first two weeks online carry most of the weight.

- **Professional photography** — the single highest-leverage dollar. Buyers meet your home online first; phone photos are the clearest tell of a weak listing.
- **A dedicated property website** — a clean address of its own that gathers photos, video, floor plans, and disclosures in one shareable place.
- **Floor plans** — often talked about, rarely delivered. They cut wasted showings and help out-of-area buyers commit.
- **Video & a 3D walk-through** — so remote and relocating buyers can tour at midnight.
- **Coming-soon / just-listed reach** — building a waitlist before launch concentrates day-one attention.
- **Broker tour + a real open-house push** — marketing to the agents who bring buyers, and to the public when it counts.



WHERE I'M GENUINELY DIFFERENT

Social marketing isn't an add-on for me — it's what I already do all day as Claudia Insider. Your home gets real reach: just-listed blasts, neighborhood storytelling, and an audience that already trusts the account. Zillow can't write what it's like to live on your block. I can.

THE LIFESTYLE SELLS THE BLOCK

Tell me your favorite things about living here — the 4pm light, the café on the corner. That's the stuff that makes a buyer picture their life in your home, and it never fits in an MLS field.

Strong marketing is a coordinated launch, not a single pretty photo. Judge it by the first two weeks — that's when urgency is built or lost.

The highest offer isn't always the *best* one.

When offers come in — often together, on the offer date — the number on top is only part of the story. A slightly lower offer with clean terms and rock-solid financing can be worth more than a high one that's fragile. Here's what we actually weigh.

HOW OFFERS WORK HERE

- **The offer date** — we set a day, release the disclosure package ahead of it, and review offers as a group. It concentrates demand and rewards prepared buyers.
- **Earnest money** — the good-faith deposit, commonly around 3% of the price, wired within about a day. A bigger deposit signals a serious, low-risk buyer.
- **Contingencies** — think of each one (inspection, appraisal, loan) as a door the buyer can walk back out of. In competitive SF offers, buyers often waive them after reviewing your pre-sale package.

WHAT MAKES AN OFFER STRONG

- **Financing strength** — fully underwritten beats "pre-approved"; all-cash removes the appraisal question entirely.
- **Clean terms & few contingencies** — fewer exits means more certainty you'll actually close.
- **Close date that fits you** — and whether they'll offer a rent-back if you need time to move.
- **Deposit size & earnestness** — real money down, quickly, is a real signal.

A RENT-BACK, AKA A SOFT LANDING

If you're buying next, a rent-back lets you stay in the home for a set period after closing — often 30, 60, or 90 days — so you're not moving twice or racing two clocks. It's one of the most useful terms we can negotiate for, and I'll weigh it alongside price when we compare offers. More on the buy-and-sell juggle in chapter 10.

What really *hits* your net.

Before we list, I hand you a **net sheet** — aka what actually lands in your pocket after everyone's paid. No money surprises later. Here's what's on it.

SF TRANSFER TAX — THE BIG LOCAL LINE

SALE PRICE	RATE ON THE PRICE
Up to \$250,000	0.50%
\$250,001 – \$999,999	0.68%
\$1M – \$4.99M	0.75%
\$5M – \$9.99M	2.25%
\$10M and above	5.5% – 6%

Customarily seller-paid in SF, and it applies to the whole price at the bracket rate — so a \$1.5M sale is about \$11,250, a \$3M sale about \$22,500. The top brackets are politically active; I confirm current rates for your sale.

THE REST OF THE NET SHEET

- **Commissions** — negotiable, with no legal "standard" rate. Since 2024, buyer-agent pay is handled off the MLS; you decide whether and how much to contribute to the buyer's side. We'll put it in writing plainly.
- **Staging & prep** — your chapter-03 choices.
- **Reports** — 3R, NHD, pre-sale inspections.
- **Title & escrow** — in SF, customarily the *buyer's* cost — a nice quirk in your favor.
- **Buyer credits / concessions** — anything negotiated at the end.
- **Mortgage payoff** — your remaining loan balance.

CAPITAL GAINS — THE ONE TO RAISE WITH YOUR CPA

If this is your primary home and you've lived there at least 2 of the last 5 years, federal law lets you exclude up to \$250,000 of gain if you're single, \$500,000 if married filing jointly — gain, not sale price. Above that, it's taxable, and California taxes the gain as ordinary income (no special rate). Improvements you've made add to your cost basis and lower the gain. I'm not a tax advisor — loop in your CPA early so there are no April surprises.

The whiplash — and how people *pull it off*.

Selling one home and buying the next in the same hot market is the timing puzzle I get asked about most. The fear is real — sell first and you're scrambling for somewhere to live; buy first and you're carrying two mortgages. Here are the levers that make it work.

BUY FIRST

Bridge financing

A short-term loan (often 6–12 months) taps your current equity so you can buy before you sell. It's fast but pricier — expect higher interest and fees — so it's a tool for a specific gap, not a default. A HELOC set up in advance can be a cheaper cousin.

SELL FIRST

The rent-back

Sell, then lease your home back from the buyer for 30–90 days. You get your equity and your proceeds, and breathing room to close on the next place — without moving twice. In a seller's market, buyers will often agree to it.

THE HARD TRUTH

Contingent offers are weak here

Making your purchase contingent on selling your current home rarely wins in competitive SF — sellers prefer clean offers. So we usually solve the timing with bridge or rent-back, not a sale contingency.

HOW WE CHOREOGRAPH IT

There's no one right order — it depends on your equity, your cash comfort, and how tight the two closings need to line up. Early on, we sketch the whole sequence together: what to line up first, where a bridge or rent-back fits, and how to keep both deals from colliding. The whiplash is real, but it's very doable with a plan — and planning it is exactly my job.

Escrow, keys, *done.*

The last stretch is mostly logistics — the deal is protected, now we land it cleanly.

Escrow is the neutral third party holding funds and documents until every condition is met; then it records, the money moves, and the home is officially the buyer's. Here's the small-stuff checklist I'll walk you through so nothing slips.

BEFORE YOU HAND OVER THE KEYS

- **Transfer the utilities** — PG&E (and CleanPowerSF), SFPUC water & sewer, and Recology for trash, recycling, and compost, effective your possession date.
- **Final professional cleaning** — once the home is empty, before the buyer's final walkthrough.
- **Gather every key & code** — door and mailbox keys, garage remotes, gate and alarm codes, smart-lock logins.
- **Manuals & warranties** — appliance booklets and any transferable warranties, left for the new owner.
- **Forward your mail** — file with USPS a couple of weeks out so final bills and documents follow you.



WHAT I'M HANDLING IN THE BACKGROUND

Coordinating staging removal and the final clean, keeping vendor invoices on the settlement statement so there are no loose ends, tracking the appraisal with comps ready to support your price, and updating you as each piece clears. You handle your move; I'll handle the paperwork.

A NOTE TO END ON

Sell it well, and *on your terms.*

Selling a home is a life event, not just a transaction. It usually sits on top of a move, a change, a new chapter — and it deserves someone who'll help you through it well rather than rush you through it.

If this guide did its job, you're a little less anxious and a lot more informed. That's the whole point — informed sellers make the calm, confident decisions that protect their equity. When you're ready to talk about your specific home, no pressure and no clock, I'd love to be your insider.

— *Claudia*

Free 20-minute consult — bring your questions, I'll give it to you straight.

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